

Confederate veterans risked Northern charges of disloyalty in organizing their own groups, but, in 1889, they created the United Confederate Veterans (U.C.V.). Without the benefaction of the Federal government, local U.C.V. “camps” established their own veteran relief associations, providing for widows and orphans, and pressuring state governments for pensions. By the early 20th century, the U.C.V. had more than 160,000 members.

To an important degree, veteran groups from the North and the South were also guardians of the memory of the war. They tenaciously promoted their own perspective on the conflict, especially through the education of children. The G.A.R. considered a pledge of allegiance as a tool in instilling a sense of nationalism. Its members also defended the legacy of emancipation. A large number of posts were integrated and its speeches and writings recalled the valor of Black soldiers and the nobility of their work as liberators. Likewise, the U.C.V. maintained a Historical Committee to review textbooks, and from 1893 to 1932 published *Confederate Veteran* as its soldiers’ voice. With articles about the war, the magazine also allowed its readers to connect with their others who had supported the rebels.

■ 400,000 The number of Union Army veterans in the G.A.R. during the 1890s.



Remembering the fallen

Civil War battle reenactments, like this one of the First Battle of Manassas, are an important educational resource. However, many public history organizations now criticize them for presenting the war as a valiant quarrel between equal and morally comparable sides.